Her one Weakness

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30752123.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Sunder (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Kidnapping, Blood and Torture, Torture, Hostage Situations, This gets real gory folks, Interrogation, Blood and Injury, Blood and Violence, Threats of Violence, Aftermath of Torture, Aftermath of Violence, I blame HTTYD fics, Heavy Angst, Angst with a Happy Ending, Angst, Pining, Protective Adora (She-Ra), Protective Catra (She-Ra), Sieges, Fluff and Angst, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Hurt, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Physical Abuse, Poor Catra (She-Ra), Lesbian Adora (She-Ra), Hurt Catra (She-Ra), Post-Season/Series 05

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2021-04-23 Words: 16,436 Chapters: 1/1

Her one Weakness

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30752123.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Sunder (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Kidnapping, Blood and Torture, Torture, Hostage Situations, This gets real gory folks, Interrogation, Blood and Injury, Blood and Violence, Threats of Violence, Aftermath of Torture, Aftermath of Violence, I blame HTTYD fics, Heavy Angst, Angst with a Happy Ending, Angst, Pining, Protective Adora (She-Ra), Protective Catra (She-Ra), Sieges, Fluff and Angst, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Hurt, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Physical Abuse, Poor Catra (She-Ra), Lesbian Adora (She-Ra), Hurt Catra (She-Ra), Post-Season/Series 05

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2021-04-23 Words: 16,436 Chapters: 1/1

Her one Weakness

by orphan_account

Summary

When a group of 3000 armed Horde soldiers and sympathizers attack Brightmoon, the castle has to be evacuated and the town is under siege

In order to let her girlfriend escape, Catra holds the invaders off and gets captured
The invaders hold her hostage in Brightmoon's tallest tower, trying to get the Alliance's location out of her
The Rebellion is hiding out in their old base far out until they can come up with a game plan

How will Adora live with knowing Catra could potentially be getting hurt? How will Catra survive being locked up in a tower and interrogated for answers? And how will the Alliance reclaim the hub of the Rebellion?

(TW : This gets violent bois, no death, but there is violence)

Notes

I broke out the swores for this bois, I never use the swores, I'm a Y7, non demonetized, Youtube Kids, Preferred Program, Cocomelon, family friendly acc. But not today

I also used one of the general guys from my other Oneshot. He's not in the blessed reboot but he's from the 1985 show, so I added him back in here as a villain bc yes

Also, I'm reading alot of HTTYD fics in my spare time these days, and dang those things are brutal, like really brutal, so be prepared for some brutal stuff in this fic

See the end of the work for more notes

"Guys, this is an open threat" Micah explained in the war room, brandishing the message "We need to take this seriously"

"We get those all the time, dad, alot of people don't like us" Glimmer tried

Scorpia shrugged "I mean, yeah, I'm the Princess of the Fright Zone, I get them all the time"

"I use mine as composting!" Perfuma chirped

"Seahawk burns mine for me, it's good practice" Mermista yawned

Adora looked down "I... don't think I get any"

Glimmer cringed "I usually get rid of them for you"

Adora shrunk into her seat "Oh..."

Catra placed a hand on her shoulder "Oh please, they're the real losers if they're writing shitty letters you'll never read"

"Catra" Bow wheezed "No swearing in the War room"

"Can we please focus" Micah said sternly "Look, I know they seem normal but this is different, we need to evacuate, I can put it past local groups, I can't put it past ex-Horde soldiers" He paused "The castle was stormed once when you were a baby, we nearly lost you that day, I am never taking that chance again"

"Dad" Glimmer reassured "We have a few guards and we have Juliet, plus, I'd like to think we're a pretty good team here" She gestured to the others

"I already sent Frosta and Entrapta home, Glimmer they have bots, soldiers, weapons, even sympathizers from the Wastes and Mystacor" He lay out several letters "Our scouts have caught them in the Fright Zone, Casta had to fire two people from her ranks, they've launched an attack on Thaymor-"

"Is that what this is about?" Glimmer interjected "Two people in Mystacor had Horde sympathies? That's how it started with Shadow Weaver, wasn't it?"

Catra flinched and Adora immediately took her hand

"That's besides the point, this is exactly how in happened before, the number of members accounts for at least 3000, too many of our guards are gone to repel the Thaymor attack, we have to evacuate!" He slammed his fist on the table

"And where would we go?" Catra questioned

"Our- Your old base camp, from when you defeated Prime, none of the civilians know about it, and as far as the Horde is concerned, it's a collapsed storage site"

Glimmer sighed "Dad, I really think we-"

boom, boom, boom

Everyone practically jumped out of their skins

Micah's eyes widened

BOOM BOOM BOOM BOOM

There was no mistaking it, it was an attack, over the castle

BOOOM

"EVERYONE RUN!" Micah bellowed

"THEY'RE IN HERE!"

Immediately there was banging on the door to the war room

Catra unsheathed her claws and hissed

Mermista picked up her trident

Perfuma got into a battle stance

Electricity generated in Scorpia's claw

Glimmer's fists turned into Sparkles

Bow held his arrows up

Adora summoned her sword

Everyone looked around uncertainly

"WE HAVE TO LEAVE" Micah yelled

"OPEN THE DOOR, YOU'RE UNDER SIEGE"

"THERE'S TOO MANY OF THEM! WE HAVE TO RUN!" Micah ordered as the door gave way

At once, several armed soldiers rushed in

"SURRENDER NOW OR DIE BY THE HORDE" One pointed his gun at Adora

Catra yelled as she tackled him

Micah drew a spell to let no one else in

Glimmer grabbed Bow and Seahawk as she teleported away

"CATRA!" Adora yelled "FOR THE HONOR O-" She was shot in the shoulder

Adora fell back with a screech

Catra roared as she clawed the shooter in the face

Glimmer came back for a split second to take Perfuma, Scorpia and Mermista

There were shouts as Micah practically held off most of the army

"GET OUT! WE HAVE TO GET OUT!" He panicked

"ADORA!" Catra rushed to her bleeding girlfriend's side

"C-ca...t..ra" Adora reached for her

Micah's spell gave way

They swarmed the room

Catra was pulled back, thrashing

"GET SHE-RA" One bellowed

"NO!" Catra took each of them on as they tried to get to Adora

Micah drew another spell "I ONLY HAVE ENOUGH FOR ONE!" He screamed

"T-ta..ke ...c..ca..t" Adora mumbled

"GET HER OUT" Catra pushed "I CAN HOLD THEM OFF"

"n..no" Adora whimpered

"CATRA!" Micah cried

"**I SAID GET HER OUT!"** Catra was cut off as she was swarmed

Micah listened and teleported Adora away

"HEY LACKEYS! BOSS HORDE PRIME IS DEAD! DEAL WITH-ARGHHH!" Was the last thing he heard before feeling the familiar 'whoosh' of teleporting

Immediately, Catra went down

"I GOT ONE!" A soldier hollered

"Hah, you got the worst out of the batch, She-Ra's already gone" Catra cackled

"Commander Catra..." One glared as he recognized her

Catra tried to ignore the seizing pain in her leg where she'd been shot "Hey, I'm not your commander anymore, didn't you get the memo? I ditched"

"How could you?! After all the Horde has done for you, you betrayed Prime!" Another soldier shouted

"Woah, is Prime the one we're worshipping now? Is that what he told you?" Catra grinned "Come on, whose really running this thing?"

"***I am"*** Said a gruff voice as he entered the room

Everyone made way for him

He was a tall, pretty old, bulky man, with grey hair, a military suit, and a gleaming badge pinned to his chest

Catra recognized him instantly, he was the guy she put in charge during their all out attack

General Sunder

He was the Horde's top general. Old man in his late forties who lead Hordak to victory before he was demoted when he lost a crucial battle. He was still looked at as an example, Adora used to look up to him at one point, all the cadets were encouraged to be like him, he used to bark at them during training simulators. Since Shadow Weaver was Second in Command, he used to hang around near her and subsequently near Catra and Adora alot. Catra had put him in charge of most battles while she strategized, but she'd never liked the guy

"The sorcerers are working on cutting off the Moonstone's connections, I've taken care of Brightmoon's general and the other guards, as of now they'll be locked away in the lower areas of the castle, see to it that they're stripped of their armor and weapons" He commanded

"Well well well" He gloated "If it isn't the honorable Commander Catra herself"

Catra hissed as she tried to claw him, she was immediately pinned down by other soldiers

"You don't seem like you're in any condition to fight, commander, abandoned again it seems" He mused "Just as you were when you first came into our ranks"

Catra huffed "Can we cut the shit here? I'm not on your side anymore, I'm the one who let them escape" She smirked "I'm the one who let ***She-Ra*** get away"

He glared down at her, the other invaders looked at her as if she'd just slapped all of them individually

She wished she had

"Aww, what's the matter? Were you expecting a showdown? Big bad Force Captain Catra going against the mighty She-Ra? that's the way it used to be, right?" She mocked "Jokes on you guys, that shit's in the past, and I just happened to let She-Ra escape"

The soldiers were practically crushing her body with the force they were pinning her down

"Look at you, I hear you even basked in Prime's favor, and you left it all for that dirty blonde wench" Sunder glared daggers at her

Catra bit back an insult "She's gone, Sunder, you can kill me and that won't bring her back"

"Oh, I do not plan on killing you..." He chuckled "I have heard stories, commander, stories of what happened on the Velvet Glove, stories of your betrayal, stories of your recent work with the Princess Alliance...stories of you and that accursed She-Ra" He grinned "You are far too valuable a prize for me to kill you now"

He faced his guards "Take her to the tallest tower in the castle and chain her there, lock the doors and bar the windows, she's valuable, and she may have a few answers we're looking for"

They pulled Catra to her feet, someone kicked her in her bad leg, she hissed

"We're treating you as a special guest, the rest of the guards are underneath this building, at least you get the highest place in the land"

Micah sucked in a breath as he smelled the familiar cold air of the Whispering Woods

A groan came from his side as Adora was practically collapsed on his arm

"Adora, are you okay?" He mouthed

Adora whimpered as she tried to get up "C- cat..."

He looked down at the bleeding gunshot wound leaking from Adora's forearm

"Oh my...we have to get you help" He whispered, lifting her up to carry her to the camp, he was a little off but it shouldn't be far "Stay awake Adora"

Adora tiredly mumbled something as he staggered across the grass

"Dad?!" Glimmer stood up as she saw him haul Adora into the camp

"King Micah! Adora!" Bow rushed to his side to help carry the blonde

"We barely escaped" Micah said gruffly "Adora's been shot...forearm...we, we need to take care of her and come up with a plan"

"I'll get alcohol and gauze!" Perfuma yelled as she began searching the crates

Glimmer hugged him "Dad, I am so *so* sorry, you were right and I should've listened and I-"

Micah shushed her "It's alright, baby girl, we wouldn't have made it out in time anyway"

"Uhhh, not to like, ruin the moment, but where's Catra?" Mermista interrupted

"Catra...stayed behind...I could only teleport one and she told me to take Adora" He said solemnly

Glimmer pulled away "Catra WHAT?! We-We have to go back, we-"

"Glimmer, it's no use, she's most likely captured, we can't go back yet" He placed his hands on her shoulders

"How can you say that so casually?! They could kill her in there!" Glimmer teared up

"That's how War is, sweetie, if you want to lead you have to sacrifice...Catra will make it, I'm sure, they aren't likely to kill a former ally" He squeezed her shoulder in reassurance "Let's just focus on caring for Adora right now, then come up with a plan"

Catra almost felt gross as they walked her up the spiral staircase to the tallest tower in Brightmoon

Her hands were tied behind her back with some pretty sturdy rope

It was the only thing that stopped her from clawing the guards pushing her and her wounded leg along

Locking her up in a tower seemed way worse than a cell

In a cell, her place was defined

She was being punished

But in a tower

She just felt like a weak and helpless girl

being held captive by the Horde

It was embarrassing

Undignified

And the worst thing was

She was being kept here on purpose

She could've easily been tossed in with Juliet and the guards in whatever manufactured prison they'd made

But Sunder had her placed here

Like she was some kind of trophy

Like she was an item he wanted to exploit

Stars, it made her sick

"This is your stop, *commander* " the invader sneered as he tossed her into the room

Catra grunted as she fell to the ground on her bad leg

"Windows are barred and chains are attached" another, less armored invader saluted

Catra looked around the room

It was circular, stone walls and a creaky wooden floor, there was sawdust littered on the ground and a lumpy pillow and blanket on one end. There was a singular window with iron bars blocking her

from fitting through, enough to give her just a sliver of moonlight during the night

The man bent down and roughly grabbed her ankle, dragging her across the floor

Catra winced again, but didn't say anything

And the next thing she felt was cool metal closing around her leg, just above her foot

The man tightened and locked it, giving the chain a few tugs that made Catra want to scratch his face off

She involuntarily hissed

"Aww, is the kitty mad?" one of the guards spoke up "Shouldn't she like her new accommodations?"

Catra sighed "They're pretty fancy, if I'm being honest, I can get a clear view of where I let the others escape to"

"They *will* be found, the general has a plan, and once they are found, we will have no reason to keep *you* alive"

The other guy glared as he shut and locked the door, keeping guard outside

Catra could hear faded noises outside from the occupation

She could hear the guard outside her cell

She can feel her leg burning from the shot that pierced it

She could feel the last of the sunlight leaking into window

She can tell it's getting dark

She could smell the musty sawdust and the creaky floor of her tower prison

She cringed at herself

She felt so useless

It was like she was waiting for some knight in shining armor to rescue her

She scratched her nails into the rope binding her hands until it finally came undone

Her knight was far away, safe, recovering from a wound Catra couldn't protect her from

And that's all that matters, right?

Her knight, her Princess, her Adora is safe

She's recovering

And just that idea alone is strong enough to keep her going

No matter what happens to her next

Glimmer and Mermista had teleported to Brightmoon's town to see what was going on, if anything went wrong, or they were spotted, she said they'd immediately get out. Micah and Bow stayed behind to make food and look after Adora and Perfuma, Scorpia and Seahawk cleaned up the base to make it more fitting for the rest of the group

Adora's vision blurred as she blinked her eyes open

"Wh-where...where am I?" she mouthed

"You're awake!" Bow sighed in relief

"What's goin o-" Adora flinched as she felt her entire arm seize

"Don't move your arm!" He panicked "You were shot...we had to pull the bullet out of you

Adora groaned as the pain set in and the memories recollected

Get her out! I can hold them off!

"Wh-where's Catra...?" Adora wheezed

Bow frowned "Adora...she's...you should rest first"

"P-Please? She's always here when I'm hurting, I-I need her, can you tell her that?" Adora was moving in an out of consciousness

"The painkillers are making her delirious" Micah sighed as he cooked soup in a makeshift cauldron "They should wear off soon though"

"How are we gonna tell her?" Bow stared up at him from his place next to Adora

"Tell her what?" Micah asked absentmindedly

Adora whimpered in her sleep again, causing a pang of pain in Bow's heart. "That Catra's been captured"

Micah sounded a little confused "I understand that they are friends, Adora should know Catra is most likely alive, and that this is what happens in a war torn world...friends get hurt and sometimes we can't protect them, what we can do is take care of them to the best of our ability"

Bow shook his head "I don't think that'll work for her"

"And why's that?" Micah added some vegetables, stirring

"Adora isn't big on people getting captured, she'll see it as a huge failure on her part, that she failed to protect her and that she needs to make it right by rescuing her as soon as possible" He paused "If I know anything about her, it's that she'll probably try to head out the moment she wakes up"

Micah sighed "I was like that too, you grow out of it once you've seen enough, it's not her fault"

"It isn't just that" Bow said sadly "Catra and Adora are more than friends...Adora loves her, they've known each other since they were kids, Catra knows her in and out, it's like one of them can tell what the other is thinking, it's like one always has the other to look out for her...Catra's the person she loves most...I can't imagine how she feels when Catra's in danger...I know I'd be a mess if it was Glimmer"

Micah looked up a little at that last statement but then went back to work "I haven't known her that long...Catra. She's never been much for talking with me, but I know she's a great person from the way she advises my Glimmer to the way she cares for Adora, not to mention her superb reflexes in battle...She's tough, I know she'll pull through"

"Tell that to Adora..." Bow sighed

"Wh-where is she Bow...?" Adora woke up again a few hours later

"Adora...what do you remember?" Bow asked quietly

Adora whimpered "Attack, Brightmoon, Horde Soldiers...we had a threat, and King Micah got us out..." She paused "Where is she?"

Bow sighed "Adora...she saved you, she got captured"

Adora's eyes widened

She blinked as she registered the words, her face morphing into abject horror

she pushed herself up, yelping as pain shot through her arm

"Lay back down!" Bow yelled instinctively

Adora began to breathe heavily "No, no, no no, why didn't you guys get her out?! She could be-"

Bow tried to get her down but she was restless "Adora, king Micah had to, he only had enough magic for one and Catra insisted he take you...Micah thinks she's safe and Glimmer's snuck into town for news, we should-"

"N-No" Adora tried to summon her sword "I need to get her back- She can't be captured, I can't let-" She bit back a sob

"Adora, you're in no condition to fight, let's just wait for Glimmer to come back with the castle's intelligence" He pushed her back down

"N-NO, I have to find her! I-I can't let them hurt her- I-" Adora was thrashing against Bow's grip now

"KING MICAH! WE NEED HELP!" Bow called

The king immediately rushed in from outside the base, casting a spell to immobilize Adora

"Why didn't you take her?!" Adora gasped as she finally fell back "I told you to! You should've left me!"

Micah sighed "And she told me to take you, you were injured worse and there was a higher chance you'd be killed if they got you, you're too valuable" He made sure Adora remained still

"You shouldn't have! You should've gotten her out! You- You-" She glared at him through tears

Micah bent down on his knee "Adora...I had no other choice, I'll do everything in my power to save her, I promise"

"Well then let me go so I can get her back!" Adora resolved

He sighed "I can't let you do that, you have a bullet hole in your arm, we need you healed before we can even think of a rescue, Glimmer and Mermista are scouting, Perfuma and Seahawk are fixing up the base, rest assured, we'll have news on Catra and come up with a plan soon"

Adora still looked unconvinced

Micah thought back to Bow's words "You know Catra better than anyone, you know she's strong, you have to trust that whatever happens, she'll pull through it"

Adora looked at him dejectedly "I just don't want her to get hurt"

"She won't" Micah sighed as he finally removed the spell and trusted Adora to lay back down

Catra looked up as someone opened the bulky metal door to her 'room'

She glared as the general strode in, swiftly locking the door behind himself

"Commander Catra" he greeted

Catra sharpened her glare "If it's answers you want, you're not getting them"

"That is very impolite" he mused "I've only greeted you and you've gone on making assumptions"

Catra chuckled "Hah, so you're the one whose locked me in a tower, shot me in the leg, taken over my home, and I'm the impolite one. Sounds about right"

"I've only come for some healthy conversation" Sunder placed a hand over his heart

"Converse away then" Catra said leisurely "You're not getting a thing out of me"

Sunder nodded as he began "Before our great siege here today, I spent weeks upon weeks researching. After your disappearance, Lord Prime summoned us, the good people of Etheria, to bring She-Ra to him and he'd set us free, bring us to the light. He said he alone knew of the She-Ras of the past, and that he alone knew She-Ra's weakness"

"Pfft, nice try, Prime said alot of dumb shit to scare people, you're not gonna find any weaknesses" Catra laughed

"Oh, but he was telling the truth" the general smirked "You see, Catra, I've searched and searched for what Prime was speaking

of, the invaluable knowledge on how to defeat She-Ra, maybe an obscure substance? Maybe a creature that could overpower her? Maybe a weapon or a poison? None made sense" He paced around the room

Catra snorted "Go for the poison, that one sounds the most stupid"

"And yet" The general looked at her "it was only a few days after he said he'd found her weakness that he had her wrapped around his finger"

Catra looked at him with an expression of mild surprise

"Strangely, he somehow made her give herself up and fly to the Heart of his empire, to surrender her ship, her friends, herself. To confront him directly in his own territory. Clearly he'd done something that didn't make her think straight, do you know what that was, commander?"

Catra stared up at him in shock

"It was you"

"No, that's not how it was it all, it was- tactical advantage-" Catra tried

A hand closed around her neck, slamming her head into the wall. Catra made a strangled noise

"Do not lie to me, Catra. I've seen you grow up with her, I've seen the two of you fight, I've searched and scoured every account of what happened on Prime's ship, read every rumor of what happened at the Heart between you two" His grip tightened around her throat

"I've already carried out a search of your little room in this castle and it's abundantly clear. She cares for you, doesn't she?" his grip

softened "That's why she went to his ship, that's why she gave herself up, because *you* were threatened. All this time, you've been her weakness"

Catra stared at him with a shocked gaze, barely able to breathe as she choked

He smirked "That seems to have broken your resolve well enough" He let her fall to the ground with a thud

"As long as I have you here, I have the Princess of Power's one weakness, I have the advantage" he grinned

"It's almost pathetic that she fell for you, someone so *weak* " He grabbed her arm and twisted it painfully behind her. Catra could feel her bones crack, despite herself, she let a cry escape "Have you learned your lesson?"

He twisted it until her shoulder dislocated "I bet she's so worried about you right now" He threw her back to the ground where she curled up against the wall

Tears pricked the corners of Catra's eyes as she glared at him

"I'll be back to interrogate you tomorrow, commander. I know you already said you won't give me answers, that's alright, I'd like to make this more fun anyway" He gestured to his dagger as he opened the door

He left the room, bolting the door shut, telling the guard to keep it locked at all times

She heard his footsteps down the spiral staircase outside

As soon as he left, Catra began gasping in pain

Her shoulder felt like it was set on fire, it made her want to scream. She grit her teeth and bit her tongue so hard it bled.

She'd been through worse, far worse, she'd fractured ribs, been stabbed, burned, literally tortured her entire life

The difference was, last time she didn't have to think about it

She'd still be with Adora as a kid, she had her goals and plans no matter how much her body ached when she was in the Horde, and she was in so much pain she was barely conscious when she was at Prime's

But now she was alone, chained up in a tower, worried sick about what the general had said

"As long as I have you, I have the Princess of Power's one weakness"

It was true, wasn't it?

Catra knew better than anyone that Adora would willingly fall into a trap for her

Hell, she already had multiple times

Stupid, self-sacrificing Adora

Catra supposed she couldn't blame her, she'd probably go beyond that for Adora

She literally just did

Pain surged up her arm again

When he came back, she'd claw the living hell out of him

She *hated* him

She hated the way he'd gotten to her

She hated the way he'd hurt her

Most of all, she hated the way he insulted Adora

Oh, she'd get him back for that

Adora

That idiot better not show up to save her

Catra was in pain, but that was leagues better than letting her girlfriend fall into the hands of their enemies

She didn't know what to do

She didn't know how they were gonna recapture Brightmoon

Even without her, Sunder had Juliet, the guards, and all the civilians hostage

She wanted to fight, escape

She wanted to do something

But there was no feasible way out

If she broke the creaky wooden floor from under her she'd have to deal with that blasted staircase

If she managed to cut the bars in the window she'd jump to her death

The door was a no go, it was guarded

The chain on her leg was reinforced, she couldn't pick it or cut through it

And if she somehow managed to get out, she'd have to navigate through the castle with a gunshot wound and a dislocated shoulder, evade getting caught, get all the way out of Brightmoon, hike through the woods, and *then* make it to their base

Yeah, no, the logical part of her brain told her she'd just cause more damage

But the rest of her just wanted to feel less helpless and weak

Catra curled up against the wall and held herself together

She was stronger than this

She always got out of stuff like this

And more importantly, she always got Adora out of stuff like this

There was no way she was going down to Sunder of all people

No matter how much he tortured her

Glimmer teleported back with Mermista, gasping

"Glimmer!" Adora yelled, trying to get up and go to her, then immediately falling back to the ground with a yelp

Glimmer looked extremely shaken "Th-The Moonstone, they cut me off...I can't use my powers..."

Micah fell to his knees in front of her "It's alright, you can still use sorcery, we'll recharge you when we get home and you'll be all better, don't worry"

Glimmer nodded "I-I know but I can't teleport, we barely managed to leave in time...and-and now I can't feel it" she looked down at her hands

Bow went around Micah and hugged her as tightly as possible, Glimmer wrapped her arms around him, taking deep breaths to calm herself down

"G-Glimmer" Adora reached out

Glimmer pulled away, looking at Adora "You're awake!"

"Y-Yeah, what's the report?" she wheezed

Glimmer nodded "The guards are all locked up in the tunnels under the castle, their armor and weapons are gone but they aren't in proper jail cells. They're under constant surveillance but Juliet's looking out for them, if we can help them escape, we'll have a better chance at taking the invaders out" She paused "The town's occupied and there's a curfew, Horde banners all over, the movement's being lead by a guy named General Sunder-"

"Sunder?" Adora sounded a little surprised "Ugh, I should've known it was him, he was crazy loyal to the Horde, we all had to

look up to him as kids, I even met him a few times growing up" She looked down, he's the one who captured Catra, she clenched her fist

"These movements form around a leader" Micah mused "Take the leader out, the movement crumbles, if Sunder's the leader here, all that matters is that we take him out and claim the castle, then we'll manage to eradicate the movement, I'll call the guild after to weed anyone else out, calling them before is risky"

"And Catra?" Adora looked to Glimmer "Is Catra with the others?"

Glimmer's expression hardened "She's alive...but a few guards saw her being taken to a...personal cell, they didn't see where..."

Adora's heart clenched, this is exactly what she was afraid of, they probably have her holed up, all alone, in some creepy dark cell. She knew Catra was strong and able to take care of herself, but the image still terrified Adora beyond belief, her Catra laying in a stone cold cell, all alone, at the mercy of *him*

Adora couldn't protect her

And that tore her up inside

"We'll get her back" Micah breathed as he poured the finally ready soup into some bowls "For now, I want you all to eat and get some rest, we'll convene for a meeting tomorrow, Perfuma and Seahawk are already in the other room, Adora, we need to change your dressings, Glimmer, I want you in bed as soon as you're done, you need your rest, Bow, I want to see if we can establish communications to Entrapta and..."

Adora tuned him out and begrudgingly ate her soup wondering what Catra was doing now

She knew Catra was extremely intelligent, she'd probably be trying to escape, she'd survey her surroundings then use them to her advantage. Catra wasn't the type to helplessly whine until she was rescued, she'd probably rescue herself

But still, Adora was frightened

Because no matter what, Catra was still the person Adora worried most for...if Sunder had put her under lock and key, in a 'personal cell' then he wanted something out of her, and that idea made Adora's stomach churn. Catra was strong, she'd never let up any information, and if she didn't then...Adora didn't want to think about it

Before she knew it, Perfuma was changing her dressings

"She will be alright, I'm sure of it" She delicately took the bandages off

Adora didn't even flinch

"She's Catra, if there is one thing I have learnt from our sessions, it's that she's strong" She cleaned the wound, and again, Adora acted like she was in no pain at all

"I just hope she's okay..." Adora whispered "He has her in her own cell, I-I'm worried about her"

"We will get her back" Perfuma finished adding the new bandages "And the first step to that is for you to rest so you can be prepared to plan tomorrow, I'd like you to go rest in the bunkers now, Seahawk, Scorpia and I set them up ourselves"

"Thanks..." Adora said quietly as she opened the door to make her way there

She couldn't sleep

This was the first time she'd slept without Catra in months

She kept yearning to feel her girlfriend there, safe in her arms

They were rarely separated these days

Attached at the hip

Every night they curled up together and went to sleep, Catra would groggily say "I love you" and then Adora would hold her close and respond with "I love you too"

She would've held Catra tighter last night if she knew they'd be separated

She hugged her pillow

"Can't sleep?" A voice came from above her

She looked up to see Bow, sitting cross legged, in front of her

Adora nodded wordlessly

"Me neither, if I'm being honest the invasion has me kinda spooked" He sat back "I mean we've dealt with worse *way* worse, but nothing's ever happened like *this* right?" He paused "I contacted Entrapta by the way, she says she keep us up to date

on what's going on from Dryl, she'll intercept any orders and transmissions in Brightmoon. Frosta's making the journey out here to help us when we take back the castle"

"Is this how you felt?" Adora asked quietly

"Hm?" Bow looked at her

"When...he took Glimmer, when you knew she'd been captured right in front of you...is this how you felt?" Adora choked out the words

After a moment, Bow nodded "Like the entire world is closing in around you? Like all you want in the universe is to find her and hug her? Like any second now you're about to hear something bad happened and fall apart?"

Adora nodded

"And you know she's strong, she can handle herself, that's what they all tell you, but you still worry. You don't doubt her but you worry, because you love her, because even the idea that she's hurt is enough for you to freak out" He confessed

"Yeah...that sounds like what I'm feeling" Adora replied, looking at him "I can't sleep without her Bow...She used to sleep in my bed in the Horde and I had to adjust to sleeping alone when I...found the sword, I don't wanna sleep alone again, I can't without her"

Bow looked at her solemnly "How about this"

He got up, went to the side of her mattress, and pushed with all his strength. The mattress skidded across the room with Adora on top of it until finally, it bumped into Glimmer's

Bow sat down again, panting "You think another 'Best Friend Squad' sleepover will help?"

Adora was overcome with emotion "Yeah...yeah I think it might"

Bow placed a hand on her shoulder "Just remember, when you find her, you're gonna hug her and never let her go, that's what kept me going"

Adora nodded as he got up and went back to his own bed on Glimmer's other side

She lay down, drawing up plans in her brain for how to best infiltrate the castle

---

Catra woke up to footsteps near her room

She positioned herself up, ready to face him

"Commander Catra, how are you doing this morning?" He greeted

Catra glared at him "I already said 'no answers' stars, can you people take a hint?"

"Arrogant as ever, I see, don't worry, we have plenty of time today to change that" He pulled out his dagger "You are going to tell me where they are, if I have the Princess of each kingdom, every single one will fall before me, and overpowering She-Ra won't be an issue"

Catra glared at the mention of Adora "Hah, fat chance, there's no way in hell I'm giving up their location"

"Come on, don't you want to help the Horde? It was your life's ambition at one point, you still have the option to rejoin us" He

held out his hand

Catra hissed "And be second to you? I'd rather not. Besides, Horde Prime is dead, it's not like whatever second rate revolution you're running is gonna last long, it's onl-"

She felt a powerful sting in her cheek as she was punched square in the face, slamming her head into the wall, she grunted in pain

"I have no interest in hearing your speeches of impertinence, hand me their location or I won't be merciful" He said coldly

Within a second, Catra got up and raised her claws, scratching him across the face

he yelled and staggered back

Catra fell back too, her wounded leg giving out

She breathed heavily, glaring at him "I was waiting to do that"

He looked genuinely enraged now "You *will* pay for that" His dagger glinted in the light

He grabbed her wrist before she could scratch again and yanked her arm forward, pinning it down

"This is your last warning" He threatened

"Do your worst" Catra hissed

He stabbed the dagger directly into her arm, it cleaved through the muscle and buried deep into her flesh

Catra's being seized as she willed herself not to scream

"You'll enter the castle through the caves underneath" Adora began, pointing to the catacombs underneath Brightmoon's castle "Bow, and Glimmer have been there before, you can access the makeshift cells and free the guards trapped down there"

Micah nodded "Sounds like it can be done but-"

"Bow is gonna take Glimmer to the chamber of Queens, from there they'll use the teleporter to get to the Moonstone, Glimmer will recharge and connect to it again, after that, you guys are gonna be able to use the Princess connection and rush the palace after freeing the guards, with a group as big as ours, we'll be able to get the castle back in no time"

Scorpia placed a claw on the table "Okay, I think this is a good plan but where-"

"After that, king Micah will call backup from the Sorcerers guild and Perfuma, Mermista and Frosta will lead the way through the town to decimate the occupation, everyone else is gonna look for General Sunder to bring him to justice, with any luck, this'll work"

"Just one question" Mermista drawled

Adora turned to her

"Where are you gonna be?" she pointed to Adora

Adora sighed "I'm gonna head into the palace earlier through one of the windows, I'll get a Horde uniform by stealing it from someone in town, after that, I'm sneaking in and getting Catra back"

Perfuma twiddled her fingers "That...doesn't sound safe"

"This part of the plan is not up for debate" Adora added, "King Micah, the table's yours"

"Right" King Micah nodded "Frosta's arriving by skiff in two nights, we'll launch the plan the midnight she gets here. Now, we'll make it into the tunnels at midnight by climbing into the Waterfalls through here, the running water and the darkness is gonna give us noise cover, after that we'll head through this tunnel, splitting with Glimmer and Bow. We'll navigate using the upwards slope of the tunnels, then we'll free the guards and rush the castle. Remember, take out the Horde guards, but Sunder is our top priority we'll..."

Adora left the table, she wasn't part of this sector of the plan so she didn't have to listen

She walked outside, into the woods, trying to get her breathing under control.

Planning always helped, at least now she had an idea of what they were doing, they'd contacted help and they knew how they were gonna get Brightmoon back

But there was still a knot in her chest

She listened to the birds singing in the woods, everything seemed so calm and perfect, but it felt like Adora was cut off from that calm world. How could everything be so relaxed? How could everything be so calm when her entire world was closing in around her? How could everything be okay if Catra wasn't okay?

"Adora?" Glimmer walked out with Bow behind her "Are you okay?"

"I'm fine" She said quietly "Just needed some fresh air"

"Glimmer and I are gonna scout to Brightmoon on foot today...maybe you could come with us, just to clear your mind" He threw her an extra pair of binoculars "We can look into the village and castle with these"

"Come on" Glimmer took her hand and pulled her to her feet "It'll be just like old times, remember when we used to traipse around the woods like we owned the place?"

Adora nodded "Yeah, I remember" She took a deep breath "You guys are right, I need to get up and start doing something useful"

"Remember, no fighting, we're only scouting and your wound isn't fully healed yet" Bow reminded her

"It'll heal faster, I'm She-Ra, and I've been hit worse, I can still fight" Adora huffed

"No, no fighting, we can't alert them" Glimmer scolded "Remember, this is a *stealth* mission"

Adora nodded "Yeah, got it, stealth. But I can still punch-"

"Let's just go" Glimmer yanked her ponytail and pulled her along

It was at least 3 hours until they reached the town

"Stars...I forgot...how much I hate...not teleporting" Glimmer panted

"I used to...live here...and I can't even...walk" Bow wheezed

"Come on guys, town isn't far" Adora looked out at the trees "We're getting near the edge of the woods and we passed the crystal castle 45 minutes ago, which means Brightmoon's just up ahead"

"Ok...Just gimme a second...t' catch my breath" Glimmer sat down

"If we climb up those cliffs there we can get a good view of the palace and the town" Bow pointed up

Adora looked up too "Good thinking, but we have to remember to stay camouflaged, we can't let anyone see us, remember?"

A few minutes later, they made their way up

"It looks like there's a guard stationed at every building in town, they're patrolling the streets, market's closed down, tons of banners, and...skiffs? They've got bots and supplies incoming, they might be setting up a transport system" Bow whispered

Glimmer took them next "The Moonstone's got a few spells over it, that's why I can't access it, it looks like, two sorcerers holding it together. Those are way above my skill level, I'm gonna need forever to undo them!" She whined before she looked to the rest "The castle's got Horde banners all over it, it looks like, yup, there's guards positioned all over- Hey! My room's ransacked! The window's broken!" Glimmer pointed to her room's huge window

Adora peered over the cliff "Yeah, that looks bad"

"And there's a shitty banner of Sunder on the wall!" She pointed to the castle walls "He looks like such an ass"

Adora glared down at it but didn't say a word

"Remind me to beat the hell out of him when we take him out" Glimmer looked back down "doors are closed, they must be trying to get the town under control, that's why the transports aren't going to the castle. there's guards patrolling-" She stopped short

Adora looked at her "What? What do you see?"

Glimmer shifted her gaze up, staring directly at the tallest tower "Are- Are those...? Oh no"

Bow lined his angle with Glimmer "What's going on at the tower? I can barely see the window from here"

Adora crouched down

Glimmer took off the binoculars and turned to her "Adora, I need you to look up there, don't freak out"

Adora raised an eyebrow "Why would I..." She took them and looked up immediately "Are those...?"

"Iron Bars" She nodded "They've barred the windows up there"

Adora dropped the binoculars and Bow picked them up, looking too, "But they haven't done that to the others, why would they..."

"That must be where they're keeping Catra" Glimmer concluded "It makes sense, the tower's small, secluded and there's no escape but the staircase, it has to be- ADORA NO" She shrieked suddenly as Adora began running back down the cliffs

"ADORA!" Bow called after her as they retreated into the woods

Adora slid down the stones following their previous path with ease, Bow jumped over the rocks and tackled her to the ground

"Let. Me. Go." Adora grunted as she practically wrestled Bow, showing surprising strength in her wounded arm

"YOU CAN'T RUN INTO BRIGHTMOON LIKE THAT!" He yelled

Adora pushed him off "Just let me leave! I'll go in and get her out!"

"YOU NEED BACKUP! YOU CAN'T RISK EVERYTHING LIKE THIS!" Bow bellowed

"YOU WOULD FOR GLIMMER!" Adora shrieked as he pulled her back again

"ADORA WE HAVE TO WAIT!" Glimmer helped Bow drag her back through the woods, away from Brightmoon

"NO! I'M NOT WAITING! I-" Adora tried but they didn't budge

Glimmer pinned her against a tree "Adora! We can't risk the plan! You can't run into Brightmoon and risk getting yourself and Catra hurt!"

Tears finally shone through Adora's eyes "He's got her trapped in a tower Glimmer! And it's my fault! What if- What if she's hurt! What if she needs me and I'm not there! What if they interrogate her?! She won't give them answers! I can't let them- It's my fault-"

"Adora" Glimmer said firmly "It's. not. your. fault. She *said* she'd stay behind, she was saving you, but it was her choice"

"Than she's an idiot!" Adora slammed her fist into the tree, sobbing "She's a complete and total idiot!"

Glimmer let her go "Adora..."

"She knows I can't see her hurt, not again- She knows I-I can't live without her, She-She knows they were after me and she still- She's such an Idiot!" Adora fell to her knees "I-I can't lose her again, I can't risk losing her again, I can't risk them hurting her"

"She was just trying to protect you" Bow reached out

"She shouldn't have to protect me! Not when she's risking her own life! I'm supposed to be the one protecting her! She's been

through enough and I never protected her then, I-I should've saved her, I can't go back- I can't" Adora breathed heavily as hot tears dripped down her face

Bow and Glimmer opted to pull her into a hug "It's gonna be okay, Adora" she said quietly "Frosta's coming in 48 hours, then we'll be ready to take them out"

"I can't risk her life for another 48 hours..." Adora sobbed into her shoulder "I can't risk her at all for another 48 hours..."

"You have to..." Glimmer sighed

They stayed like that for at least five minutes

Bow helped lift her up "Ok, let's take this step by step, we're gonna get back to camp, you're gonna eat something and change your dressings, then we'll call Entrapta for a briefing and you'll go to sleep"

Adora mumbled something as the other two helped her walk

Sunder kicked her in the ribs again "Are you willing to give me answers now?"

Catra gasped for breath and whimpered as the feeling of breathing ached her body, tears stained her bruised cheek as she looked back "I told you...I'm not that easy to break..."

He'd stabbed her in the arm and twisted the knife until she finally broken and screamed. Her back was practically cut open with

large red slashes crisscrossing over her skin, it hurt and stung and she'd cried but she gave him nothing. She had a large, blossoming bruise on her cheek with a black eye to boot, even speaking stung, she had a pretty much dented ribcage from all the kicking and the beating, but she still gave him nothing

"I'm afraid that concludes our time for today" He glared "I will be back tomorrow for an answer"

"Y-you won't get one then either" Catra hissed, curling into the cold, rough wall on her side

"If it's any consolation your wounds will heal easily, I need you alive if I want She-Ra defeated don't I?" He smirked

Those were the only words that seemed to instill actual fear in Catra "Y-you stay away from her..."

He grinned "And whose going to stop me, you're in no condition to fight" He bent down on his knee in front of her "When I capture her, I might just keep her alive, so I can kill her in front of you"

"Bastard" Catra cursed "I'll kill you for this, when I get out, I'll *kill* you for this"

He smiled again "I don't think someone in your position should be shouting bold threats like that"

"You know as well as I do that they're out there and coming up with a plan, your measly crew can't take the full power of She-Ra and the alliance, they've defended against the full might of the Horde and still won, every minute I don't give you an answer is a minute the Princesses can use for an attack" She monologued "You might have me in this cell but I'm the one who can make or break your shitty revolution"

He looked down at her angrily before smiling again "You make a good strategist, I'll say that much" He walked over to the door

and opened it "I'll be back tomorrow commander, I ask again that you *think over* what I've said and done today"

"How was scouting?" Micah asked as Glimmer and Bow dragged Adora into the base

Bow sat her down at the table, pulling the chair out for her and pushing it back in. Adora looked...lost, her face was just emotionless, there were bags under her eyes from the crying earlier, and there was a rip in her pants from when Bow tackled her

"I'll get food in a minute, 'kay?" He told her as he left to brief King Micah

Scorpia pulled up a chair next to her "Hey Adora! We're just getting briefed on the scouting mission and guess what? Slight hiccup in our calculations Frosta's arriving on the morning day after tomorrow! Not the night, so we have tons of time to brief her!"

Adora nodded wordlessly

"Oh! And y'know we just contacted Entrapta, she's giving us live updates on Brightmoon all the way from Dryl! How cool is that? I gotta tell ya this tech stuff...hey are you even listening?" She asked a little worriedly

Adora lifted her head "Huh, oh yeah, Entrapta, got it"

Scorpia tried to look her in the eye "Hey, did something happen while scouting?"

Adora willed herself not to cry again "He's locked Catra up in the tower...Bow, Glimmer and I saw bars up there, he's holding her there like- like she's some kind of-"

"A tower?" Perfuma sipped her hot chocolate "You have to rescue her from a tower? That sounds just like a fairytale!"

Adora's brows furrowed "What does that mean?"

"Oh, it's enchanting, the story goes that the Princess is trapped in a tower, either by a dragon, or a witch, or any other villain character, and then her knight in shining armor comes to rescue her and they defeat the villain together and share true love's kiss! It's so romantic!" Perfuma generated flowers in her hands as she told the story

"Aww, that sounds so sweet!" Scorpia smiled

Adora felt a pain in her head "Sound's silly"

Mermista pulled up a chair after listening in "Hey, just because Catra isn't here doesn't mean you get to act all moody like her, that fairytale is a classic, the rescues are like, so cute"

"Those are my favorite part!" Perfuma giggled

"Ooh, where can I read one of these?" Scorpia asked excitedly

"Okay can you guys *stop?* " Adora interrupted "This isn't a story, this is real life! My girlfriend's been captured by insane mercenaries that could be doing anything to her right now and you're all here talking about- about kid's stories!" She turned to Perfuma "Does the villain have guns, machines, and an army behind them? Are they literally gonna murder the Princess at any moment?! Does the stupid knight ever worry or do they treat it like it's another stupid quest?! Do they even show how much time

she has to wait?! How much time there is for anything bad to happen to her and for that stupid knight not to be there?!" She was nearly in tears again by the end

Perfuma looked a little hurt "No, but-"

"Then you don't get to compare! This is real, I know you guys lived outside the Horde but none of you, and I mean NONE of you know the kind of stuff Sunder's done to people. You haven't seen the prisons, you haven't heard the screams, you guys don't even have cells!" She banged her fist on the table "You don't get to say that when you have literally no idea what I might be letting happen to her!"

Scorpia and Mermista looked completely shocked while Perfuma just looked regretful

"I-I apologize" She said quietly " I was just trying to lighten the mood...I shouldn't have trivialized your problem"

"No, it's me who should say sorry, I'm the one who lived there too, even if the memories are repressed, I should've known not to bring that up" She placed a claw over her heart

"Yeah, sorry Adora" Mermista said shortly but sincerely

"Just...just don't compare that stuff" Adora sat back down "Not when you have no idea what it actually means"

"I think we should change your dressings now, Adora, at least before Entrapta calls in"

Adora got up quietly after her outburst, following Perfuma into the other room

"Sorry I shouted" Adora said quietly as she sat down on the ground

"No, you had every right to, I was being tone deaf" Perfuma undid Adora's bandages for the second time

"I just- I saw those bars and I froze...I could imagine her sitting up there, thinking of ways to escape" She looked down "I even thought she might just rescue herself if I'm not fast enough but then I started to remember" Her voice cracked "...Sunder's ruthless, he-he's horrible to people, whenever he was on the night watch, there were screams from every prison cell, he'd interrogate them, try to force answers out of them. He'd-He'd even lay out a bunch of weapons and use them on people one by one"

"That's-That's horrible, I'm sorry you had to witness that" Perfuma applied the alcohol, pausing to look up at Adora again

"He put her in the tower because it's one place she can't escape from. She can't climb down the tower, it's too tall, if she takes the inside, she'll have the staircase and guards everywhere to deal with"

"So instead I imagined her waiting, waiting for us to come back, waiting for the right time to attack...maybe even waiting for me to rescue her..." She sighed "And I'm not there, I should be protecting her but I'm not there, she might be hurting and I'm not there, I don't want her to have to wait, I don't want to risk her, I can't-"

"It'll be alright" Perfuma tried "Just remember that, we've faced worse, everything will turn out alright" She finished bandaging

Adora's arm again "You should have dinner and sleep after our call with Entrapta, you can't rescue her if you're not healthy"

And so Adora did as instructed, she ate as Entrapta ratted off a bunch of updates to the others, only taking mild interest in what she was saying

"Oh! And I almost forgot! He's sent a broadcast out" She played something on the screen

"At long last, after several years of waging war, Etheria is finally under the control of the Horde. Today is a joyous day, where the planet elects a new leader to take charge and bring Lord Prime's great philosophy to this corrupted world. Though those in the Rebellion are still at large, Brightmoon has fallen, and they've all gone into hiding, if you are listening from wherever you are, remember, I will slaughter every being that gets in my path to bring you out of hiding and to justice. As of now, the Princesses are fugitives, and the kingdoms of Etheria must surrender to me within a week or be occupied by force, any who resist will face severe consequences. The Horde sees all, the Horde knows all"

Entrapta turned it off "Isn't it fascinating?"

"Pfft, he sounds like the obvious suspect from a Mer-Mystery book" Mermista joked

"No, no, more like the type of Pirate whose ship we'd burn down" Seahawk replied, causing them both to burst into fits of giggles

"Don't get fooled" Adora said through gritted teeth "He's still a huge threat, he's just operating out of Prime's playbook"

Entrapta spoke through the screen again "Yes but my calculations say the that you all have a 90% chance of beating him once

Frosta arrives" She paused "Are you sure you don't want me to make the journey out? I have absolutely no trouble and-"

"No" Mermista said firmly "You're all types of cool, geek Princess, but you're our only line of proper communication, we need you with your tech at Dryl"

"Hmmm" Entrapta nodded "According to the data you are correct, I'll make the trip out to Brightmoon once it's saved though, I'd like to be with my friends"

"Sounds wonderful!" Perfuma smiled "I'll bring snacks!"

Adora left the table, pushing her chair back as she slowly got up and walked to the bedroom

Glimmer looked back at her "Adora..."

"I'm going to sleep, guys" She said quietly

"Oh..." Bow was actually surprised she was willingly going this time "Do you want us to-"

"I can make it alone" She didn't look at him as she spoke, leaving for the bunkers

Adora crashed onto her bed and pulled the covers over immediately, her vision of the floor of camp fading away as her eyes closed

And when she opened them, she was back in Brightmoon

What the...?

The castle was ransacked and abandoned

"Adora!"

Adora ran across the halls "Catra? Where are you?!"

"ADORA!"

She opened every random door as the castle twisted and warped

Horde banners began decorating the area

The world went red

The stained glass widows began to change

Finally, she found the door to the tower and threw it open, sprinting up the spiral staircase

"ADORA!" Catra cried out from the room her hands quaking as she banged on the door, she looked terrified "ADORA HELP ME!"

"CATRA! HOLD ON! I'M GONNA GET YOU OUT OF THERE!" She tried to open it with brute force, but nothing worked

Catra whimpered and Adora could hear her crying

With one final yell, she threw the door open

Catra was hurt, badly, she was hesitant as she looked at Adora

"I-I'm here, I'm getting you out" She reached her hand to caress Catra's cheek "It's ok-"

Catra froze as a figure approached from behind her

"If it isn't She-Ra herself" general Sunder smirked, he yanked Catra away from Adora and threw her to the ground

"You..." Adora glared "LET HER GO!"

"Why should I?" He chuckled "You allowed her to fall into my hands, you hesitated to save her when you knew what I'm capable of" He pulled out a stun baton, and Catra screamed

*"You have no one to blame but **yourself** " Sunder laughed mercilessly*

Catra cried out again, "ADORA!"

Adora screamed as she ran at him, but she couldn't seem to get to them, it was like she was trapped behind an invisible wall "STOP IT!" She yelled "STOP IT! LET HER GO!"

But he didn't stop, he tortured her the way he had so many others, and this time Adora was forced to watch as she begged him to stop

Catra's eyes hurt the worst, they were filled with pain and heartache and betrayal. Betrayal because Adora failed to save her, Adora failed to protect her, Adora landed her here

Adora lurched up in bed, panting, it was just a nightmare, everyone was still eating dinner

She turned on her side and tried to calm her breathing, but it felt near impossible without Catra's warm mass next to her

Catra was practically covered in dry blood by the time the morning moons rose

She remembered hearing these guys was brutal but she wasn't prepared for exactly *how* brutal

It hurt to move, it hurt to breathe, it even hurt to think

She could feel her cracked ribs groan and ache with every breath, her back scream as it was lined with cuts, one arm burning because it was dislocated and the other because it had been stabbed

But she still held on

Even if she was an inch from death here, she'd never give up Adora's, or any of the other princess' location

If there was one thing the entire Rebellion gave Catra credit for, it was that mental toughness that no one around her could break

When she put her mind to something, there was no stopping her

And right now, she'd put her mind to never giving up the information Sunder wanted

Speaking of Sunder

Catra flinched as she heard footsteps up the stairs

Here we go again

Sunder stepped into the room, armed with a stun baton this time

"I've given you the night to consider my lecture" He spoke leisurely "Do you have an answer for me yet?"

"Still no" Catra croaked

"We'll be using the batons today, I'm sure you are familiar with these" Electricity crackled as he shifted the option between 'controlled shock' and 'lethal strike' stopping just at the border of the red zone

"Red, bold choice" Catra observed, but the fear in her voice betrayed her

He looked up "Let's get started, shall we?"

"Frosta's coming tomorrow" Micah walked around their makeshift table as he spoke "In light of that I think we should go through the plan for a second time"

Everyone nodded

Micah breathed deeply "First off, Adora will be leaving for Brightmoon earlier in the day on her own mission to rescue Catra, she'll be well disguised and sneak in through Glimmer's broken

window in her room. From there she'll make her way up to the tallest tower and stand guard outside Catra's door until the night's moons are all visible in the sky" He looked at her "Remember, if anyone's there, they'll have to climb the staircase for at least two minutes before they reach you, you'll have no trouble disarming and knocking them out. No matter what you see, no matter what happened, you will not talk, you will not heal, you will not transform in any way and you are *not* gonna try to get her out. If you're caught, they won't show you any mercy"

Adora nodded begrudgingly

He sighed "Alright, we'll follow this path right up here, I'll use a simple but effective cloaking spell to make sure there is no way we'll be spotted, the running water will make sure we're not heard. After reaching the tunnels we're gonna split up with Bow and Glimmer, what will you do then, sweetie?"

Glimmer got up "Bow and I are gonna access the teleportation device in the chamber of queens that takes us directly underneath the Moonstone, Bow will keep the sorcerers at bay while I undo the spells. It'll take around 15 minutes but dad's been talking me through it, I'm sure I can do it. After that I'll teleport Bow to you and you'll storm the palace. Then I'll teleport to Adora and Catra and give her the go ahead to free her and join us in battle"

Adora raised her hand "How much time do I get before I have to go?"

Glimmer coughed "Around five minutes, then we *need* the princess connection"

"Ok no, we need a backup for that, I'm *not* leaving Catra alone in that tower" Adora stood up too

"Adora" Glimmer tried "We have to do this in order to save Brightmoon, we have a better chance of winning if-"

"I've saved Brightmoon a million times, I could be dying and I'd compromise that to protect Brightmoon, I've been part of every battle, I've given everything I have, Etheria's always come first" She paused "That stopped at the Heart, whatever happens, if Catra needs me, I'm not going down that tower, she's my top priority" She was Catra's hero first, Etheria's second

"Adora..." Glimmer's argument died in her throat

"You guys don't get to lecture me on this, you'd all do it if you were in my shoes. What if it was Bow, Glimmer?" She faced her

Glimmer opened her mouth before nodding in admission "Okay, let's brainstorm a backup"

"We all have to be fighting for the connection to work" Perfuma reminded them "I can't generate plants out of nothing without the connection"

"Ok, here's the plan" Adora interrupted "You, Mermista, Frosta, take the East Wing, the gardens are right down the hall, you'll have plenty of plants and water there, you can use that while charging at the invaders in the area, remember, we have guards here so they can weed them out along the area. Bow, Glimmer, Micah, Scorpia, take the West let the guards rush the others and focus on the throne room, that's where Sunder probably is. Catch the invaders and lock them where the guards were locked before. Once we free the castle, the Princesses go first in storming and taking back the town, once the danger's gone someone can stay behind with Catra and I'll help against the larger army outside, they have bots so we have to be careful. We'll access the connection then and have them running like we did in the Battle of Brightmoon"

"I'm not on the connection, I'll stay with her" Bow volunteered

Adora nodded

"And remember, this is just in case you guys can't join us" Micah added

Adora nodded again

"Well, if that's settled, let's get an update from Frosta, then we'll call Entrapta in for a briefing" Glimmer left her chair "Meeting adjourned"

"Had enough yet?" Sunder asked casually as Catra breathed heavily on the ground

He'd shocked her multiple times all morning, to the point where she'd literally screamed in agony several times. There were large red burns where the stun baton made contact, leaving her writhing on the floor. And still, despite all the crying, despite all the screaming, she managed to retaliate

"Not even close" She panted, tears streaming down her cheeks

This wasn't working, it was time to switch to plan B

"You know, this little charade is starting to get old" He bent down in front of her "You look pathetic with what you've been reduced to. I remember a time when you were the fearless warrior of the

Horde, the top strategist, the second in command. And now look at you"

Catra propped herself up against the wall "Heh, I'd still like to think I'm fearless, I've taken all this shit and not given you a single word"

"I have been thinking on your words from the previous night, Catra" He monologued "Every day the Princesses are hiding, working, planning on bringing me down, and I'm no closer to finding them and ending them, I'm no closer to ending She-Ra"

Catra chuckled "No you aren't, and you never will be"

He looked her in the eyes "And you...you seem so devoted to them, it's hard to imagine you were their enemy. And you're so devoted to She-Ra in particular, you'd never risk a hair on her head"

The smile dropped from Catra's face "Where are you going with this?"

"She-Ra will not be found by me, she's hidden too well, and you will take the secret of where she is to your grave. After all, I can break her with her weakness once she's here, but I can't break you no matter how much I try to find yours" He paused "But that's the curious thing isn't it?"

He tilted Catra's chin upwards

"All this time, I've been trying to utilize you for the wrong purpose, I believed physical torture was enough for you to give me their location, but there is no conceivable way you will, this was never the purpose I should've been using you for" He forced Catra to look at him "After all, why use you to find She-Ra, when I can use you to bring She-Ra to me?"

Catra froze as her eyes went wide

"I have her weakness right here, I have what she loves most, I have *you* " He chuckled "If you are so devoted to her, she must be just as to you, Lord Prime was able to bring her to his ship with no issue, even though she absolutely knew it was a trap, why is there no reason I can't do the same?"

Catra stammered "She-She won't come, she's not dumb- knows the r-risk, Y-you can't-"

"Oh, but I can" He snarled "You seem to know her well, how would she react if she saw that you were locked in a tower? How would she react if she saw your condition? How would she react..." He picked up his dagger and pressed the tip of it to Catra's chest "...If I gave her an ultimatum?"

Catra gasped heavily, and Sunder knew she was broken

"Ha! I am right aren't I? She will come for you, and when she does, I'll have her killed before your eyes" His finger glided over the cool metal of the blade "If I threaten your life, she'll have no choice but to walk into my trap"

"No, no-" Catra stammered, but it was too late

Sunder lifted her up by the neck "This is going to be fun" He grinned

---

"And those are the recent updates from Brightmoon!" Entrapta squeaked as she explained the guards, stations, and supplies

Glimmer jumped up excitedly "We can ambush the supply line after taking the town back! They won't expect it to be freed when they deliver the stuff!"

"And wherever the supply's coming from has to be their Headquarters" Bow added "If we can manage to find it, we'll decimate the movement and get a ton of new information-"

"Information?! Please let me preserve it! I could make data charts. effectively distribute supplies and track down where most of these sympathizers came from!" Entrapta interrupted

"Sounds helpful" Micah smiled encouragingly "We'll be sure to call you in once we've secured the town"

"Great!" she grinned

Adora looked at the screen tracking Frosta's location over and over again

"You good there, Adora?" Mermista asked "Y'know she isn't gonna move any faster because you looked at her"

Adora sighed "I-I'm fine, just, the moment Frosta gets here, I'm taking off, I'm not waiting another minute"

"Sounds like a plan" She placed a hand on her shoulder

"You-You don't think I'm freaking out too much? Checking the screen over and over, barely listening to briefings-" She asked anxiously

"No you aren't, as much flak as I give my goober, I'd be the same if it was him in that situation" She paused "Even if Catra and I don't always get along, I can tell you love her, and if a stone cold heart like mine can see that, you've got something special. If she's in danger, you have every right to worry"

"Wow...I never expected to hear that from you" Adora said, relieved

"Meh, what can I say, I'm full of surprises" She drawled

"Ooooh! General Sunder just released another announcement!" Entrapta looked at her tablet "It's happening LIVE! All of Etheria's watching! Hold on, I'll let you guys-" Her screen cut off as Sunder's face was displayed instead

"This is a message for the woman who has been hiding and cowering in fear for the last two days since my arrival" He began "The one who has risked all of Etheria to preserve her own life multiple times, the one who supposedly thinks she's brought down Horde Prime, this is a message for She-Ra"

All people at the table glanced at Adora

The blonde's eyes narrowed as she looked up at the screen

"You have allowed your planet to suffer in darkness, you have preserved the darkness for countless millennia. You parade around being hailed as the one who vanquished Lord Prime and yet you've been hiding away like a coward" He paused "If you have an ounce of integrity left, you will come to Brightmoon before Midnight tonight, you will surrender your sword and you will be taken into my custody"

Mermista and Seahawk were silently giggling to themselves about how lame his demands were

"And just in case you back out-" The camera panned to the side, and what they saw made the entire Rebellion freeze

Catra was being held back by guards, her hands tied firmly behind her back. She was covered in bruises and burns, her cheek was deep red while one of her eyes was swollen with a tinge of purple, her right shoulder looked deformed and broken and her left had a gaping, untreated stab wound, there were multiple slashes across her body and a huge gunshot wound on her left leg

Seahawk and Mermista's joking ceased

Perfuma audibly gasped with tears in her eyes

Scorpia tore her eyes away from the screen

Bow looked beyond terrified

Glimmer covered her mouth

King Micah looked disgusted

Adora's face was a mix of emotions, surprise, fear, anger, horror. Her eyes were wide and her pupils were pinpricks, her eyebrows creased in worry, her mouth hanging open as she tightly gripped the table to steady herself

Catra's ears perked up as she saw the broadcasting device, she struggled against the two guards with a surprising amount of strength as she screamed "ADORA! ADORA DON'T-"

The video panned away from her

"Do not try anything when you arrive here or *she* won't live to see it" He pulled out his dagger "Remember, if you don't meet my demands by midnight, she dies"

And the video cut out

Entrapta returned to the screen "Okay...that was...not as good as I expected" She scratched the back of her head

Immediately the alliance erupted into loud noises as the reality set in for them

Glimmer was bawling her eyes out "If- If I'd just teleported her-"

"I should've let Adora go, I should've let Adora go-" Bow chanted to himself

"I can't believe you compared that to a fairytale!" Mermista yelled at Perfuma

"I-I had no Idea!" Perfuma gasped through tears

"And why didn't **you** tell us about this!" She slammed the table as she looked to Scorpia

Scorpia hid behind her own tail "I never saw...didn't remember...I didn't"

"EVERYONE QUIET DOWN!" King Micah tried

"We have to rescue her tonight!" Seahawk concluded "I say we fight them without Frosta!"

"We can't go yet, it's a trap!"

"So just because it's a trap we can let Catra die?!"

"IF IT'S A TRAP *ADORA'S* GONNA DIE!"

"HOW CAN YOU TELL THAT?! MAYBE WE CAN DO SOMETHING!"

"WE CAN'T DO THIS WITHOUT FROSTA-"

"WE CAN'T DO ANYTHING WITHOUT ADORA-"

"SHE'S ARRIVING IN 12 HOURS WE CAN TAKE THE CASTLE!"

"HE'S GOT A KNIFE TO CATRA IN THERE IF HE SEES US HE'LL DO IT!"

"WE HAVE TO-"

"WAIT" Bow finally yelled "Where's Adora!?"

The entire table went quiet as they looked to the exit, just fast enough to see the plants having been moved aside and the faint, fading yellow glow coming from She-Ra

Glimmer was the first to get up, running to the exit "ADORA! WAIT! COME BACK! WE NEED A PLAN- ADORA!"

But by the time she was outside, Adora had already gone, sprinting through the woods in her She-Ra form faster than any of

them could keep up

They'd lead Catra to the throne room in anticipation for Adora's arrival

"She-She's not coming, you don't even know if she's seen it, there's no way, you're wasting your time-" she gasped as she was pushed into the room

Sunder was lounging on the throne, watching the time for Adora's arrival

"Well, we should give her until midnight then, should we not?" He smirked

Catra kept worriedly glancing to the entrance

"Today will be a day of reckoning in the History of Etheria. Where I, general Sunder, will go down as the legend who defeated the mighty She-Ra" He announced "The Princess Alliance will cower and fall before me without their precious hero! I will go on a conquest to finally conquer and unite Etheria referring to the ideals of the Horde, I will break every runestone in my path" He looked down at Catra "And it will all be because of *you* "

Catra glared up at him "She's not coming"

BANG

There was a loud noise coming from the entrance of the castle

Catra's eyes widened

Sunder laughed out loud as he walked off the throne "Are you sure about that, commander?"

The guards passed Catra over to him, he held her back and pressed the flat of the dagger to her throat, Catra hissed as she tilted her head upwards

BOOM

The doors to the throne room flew open as She-Ra burst in, her sharp blue eyes glaring at Sunder and the guards

Catra gasped as she tried to escape

"If it isn't She-Ra herself" Sunder grinned as his arm tightened around Catra "I was afraid you wouldn't show up"

Adora scowled at him, her hand tightening around her sword "Let. Her. Go."

"Not so fast" He smiled "you have yet to fulfil all my demands, drop your sword and relinquish your She-Ra form"

"Adora...don't-" Catra was abruptly cut off as he pressed the dagger harder to her neck

That seemed to frighten Adora enough

Her sword dropped with a clang as She-Ra flickered away, leaving behind a much smaller girl in a frayed red jacket

Adora grit her teeth as she held her hands up in surrender

Tears filled Catra's eyes as she tried to kick at Sunder and escape

Sunder snapped his fingers "Restrain her"

Adora willingly bowed her head as the guards twisted her arms behind her, holding her in place

She looked up at Catra's teary, terrified eyes, the cuts and bruises on her face, they looked so much worse in person

She glared at Sunder again "There, you have me, now *let her go* "

"And why would I do that?" He grinned

Adora's eyes blazed with anger as she looked up at him

"I have learnt many things throughout my conquest She-Ra, the first being that every one has a weakness. From every miniscule creature on this planet to the Princesses themselves, all have some strategy to defeating them"

Catra struggled against his grip again

"I've been searching, scouring for your weakness for so long, what I failed to realize was the she's been right here all this time" He said gleefully "No matter what powers of invincibility the universe rewarded to you, you allowed yourself to care about one small, insignificant being, you willingly risk everything for her, you'd give your life for her. She's your weakness"

He laughed as he pressed the dagger deeper, tearing skin and letting droplets of blood ooze out

Fear shot across Adora's expression as she held her breath

"So why should I consider letting her go?"

Adora snarled "Stop it, she's not involved here, you have She-Ra, leave her out of this"

"I don't think you're in a position to negotiate here"

He let Catra fall to the floor with a gasp. She quivered as she fell to her knees and looked up at Adora, just from her eyes Adora could tell what she was saying

you shouldn't have come here

Adora looked down at her and the glare melted off her face, her eyes softened as she looked into Catra's "It's okay" she mouthed

And suddenly she felt the sharp poke of a stun baton on her back, just in between her shoulder blades

"Let's see if *she* knows how to answer questions any better than you" He charged the stun baton to full

Adora's eyes widened

"Tell me where the Rebels are hiding and their plans"

Catra looked up at Adora and shook her head "Don't-AHHHH" She screamed, kneeling over to reveal all the massive cuts on her back

"CATRA!" Adora yelled

Sunder looked at Adora "I didn't hear an answer, She-Ra"

For the first time since she arrived, Adora showed true fear on her face. She couldn't sell her friends out, but she couldn't let Catra hurt anymore, she drew in a deep breath

"Th-they're in the Crystal Castle, big ancient ruins in the middle of the woods" She lied "They'll attack with weapons and reinforcements in a week"

Catra caught her eye. Adora lied, she was lying through her teeth. She tried to look horrified at what the blonde had said

"See?" He poked the baton a little deeper into her back before pulling away "That wasn't so hard, was it?"

He looked back at Adora

"Oh how the mighty have fallen, how you could care for someone so insignificant is beyond me, She-Ra. It was only a matter of time until someone exploited this weakness within you" He picked up her sword from next to her foot and admired it "A power greater than anyone can imagine, and you've given it all up for someone so weak"

"I gave you your answers, didn't I? Now just let her go" Adora snarled

He looked back down at Catra "I don't see why she matters to you, she's nothing, less than nothing, and you let her become your weakness"

"I SAID LEAVE HER ALONE!" Adora finally yelled

"See? That kind of backtalk isn't permitted here" Sunder stood behind Catra again, sword in hand "She's practically useless to me, I can just dispose of her now"

Adora began to struggle against the guards "NO"

He raised Adora's sword over her

Catra scrunched her eyes shut

Adora yelled

All of a sudden, her eyes blazed bright blue

blue flames erupted from her body

Her hair came undone, flying behind her

The guards flew back

Adora glared at him in pure, unrelenting rage

He tried to bring the sword down but it glitched back into Adora's hand

"I already told you to *let her go*" Her voice was distorted

Yellow lightning flew across the room, crackling and exploding all over, Adora morphed back into She-Ra as she flew towards Sunder with a yell, punching him into the wall

The guards screamed and began to run, abandoning their weapons

Catra looked at her, half surprised, half terrified

The flames heightened as Adora looked at all the wounds on Catra's body, they began to cover the room, but they didn't seem to touch her

Adora yelled again as she ran at him, punching him multiple times

How dare he? How dare he hurt her

She kicked him

How dare he lock her up

The fire and lightning crackled as they burned him

How dare he use her as bait

"You don't *get* to talk about my weaknesses..." She spoke "You don't get to use her against me, you don't get to call her that" Her voice was calm but anyone could tell she was livid

"You may have found my weakness, but that's a double edged sword" She looked down at him, now he was the one cowering in

fear "She's my greatest strength, she's made me into what I am... and if you hurt her, you'll have someone way worse than just She-Ra to deal with" She slashed his arm with her sword "You'll have to deal with *me* "

Adora had never been more angry in her life

She was outraged, Catra didn't even think she could see Adora in there anymore

Her eyes were blazing, angry, filled to the brim with She-Ra's dangerous blue

Her voice was completely distorted as she yelled

There were waves of energy, dancing fire, and sharp, striking lighting pouring everywhere but her

And she hit Sunder until he'd been knocked out

Catra's eyes widened as she raised her sword

This wasn't Adora anymore

Catra couldn't recognize her, she'd never kill anyone, she was too lost in her anger

"ADORA!" She yelled

And immediately, the lightning stopped

The fires went out

The energy in the atmosphere shifted

Adora's hair stopped flying in waves

Her eyes fell back into their calm, iridescent blue, she looked at Catra for a split second

She glanced back at Sunder's limp body, he was knocked out, scratches and burns all all over him, she glared at him before turning around

Catra was still sitting on the floor, wounded terribly

She tried to push herself towards Adora, her hands still tied behind her back

Adora ran towards her, She-Ra flickering away again

She pulled Catra into her arms, holding her more selfishly than she had in a long time

Catra winced, it hurt slightly, but not as much as she was expecting

Adora held her protectively, glancing around to make sure no enemies were there before crying into Catra's hair

"I'm okay" Catra rasped "I-I'm okay"

Adora sobbed even harder "No you're not you idiot!"

Catra felt the familiar warmth of She-Ra's healing coursing through her, she knew she'd need multiple sessions for it all to go away, but she could feel her body literally stitching itself back together. The ones on her legs and back shrunk, the stab wound and the bullet hole felt less deep, the burns became more bearable, her shoulder popped back into place, the bruises on her face felt more dull, she could feel the pain in her black eye subside. She could see herself and Adora being enveloped in warm yellow

she chose to just sit in silence while Adora cried her eyes out. It wasn't like there was much she could do, besides talk, her entire body still hurt like hell. "Shh, Adora, it's okay"

"No it's not!" Adora sobbed "He almost killed you! He's been torturing you for days! He-He hurt you"

Catra sighed softly "P-please don't yell anymore..."

Adora abruptly shut her mouth before talking in a softer tone "Why did you have to stay behind? You could've let him take me, they got to me first, you shouldn't-"

"You're no one to talk" Catra breathed "You'd...do the same for me..."

"I- That's besides the point" She tried to collect herself "You know I can't see you hurt. You know I can't lose you again and you-you just-"

"It's okay..." Catra murmured soothingly, causing a fresh cascade of tears to come from Adora

"ADORA! CATRA!" Glimmer and Bow yelled in unison as they fell to their knees near them

"What happened?!" Glimmer asked softly

"The invaders were all running off, they said there was a crazy monster blowing stuff up in here" Bow added "Are you okay?"

" 'Dora saved me, M'fine" Catra mumbled

"You two better see this" Micah called from the other end of the room

General Sunder's beaten body was laying amongst a ton of rubble, part of the wall was pushed back and there were large cracks all over

"He's alive, we better take him into custody" Micah ordered

Glimmer nodded shakily, glancing back to Adora, who still had her face buried in Catra's hair

"We should get them back to their room and get a med kit" Bow spoke as he eyed Catra's injuries

"It's nearly morning, Frosta's coming soon, we'll free the town then, though they're already running off" Micah observed

"I'll call up the Sorcerers guild to put Sunder in jail" Glimmer added, right now we need to fix the town and fix this place

Bow walked back "Adora? Catra?" He urged

Catra flicked her ear as a sign that she noticed him

"You guys should get back to your room, I'll be there with a med kit in a second" He said softly

It was a moment before Adora responded with a nod

She finally let her tear stained face up, there were massive bags under her reddened eyes

She slowly got up, practically gliding through the air with Catra protectively shielded in her arms

---

Adora pushed open the door to their room with her back

Their stuff was strewn all over the place, but it was nothing she couldn't clean up in an hour

She quietly walked over to the couch, gently placing Catra down, finally untying her

"You stay here, okay babe? I'm gonna go clean up and get the med kit" She ran a hand through Catra's hair

"Hmmm" Catra hummed in acknowledgement as she snuggled into the cushions

Adora wasted no time in tidying things up, glancing back to her girlfriend and giving quiet reassurances every few minutes

Eventually, Catra sat up, quietly responding to Adora's words until Bow opened the door and slid the med kit inside

Adora picked it up and locked the door with a 'click'

"Catra?" Adora asked as she walked up to her "Can I take a look at you?"

"Heh, you sure you're not tired, dummy?" She joked

"I'm not tired when it comes to you" Adora said firmly

Catra scooted forward, once again revealing all the cuts and slashes on her back, Adora visibly recoiled as she saw the excess of dried blood matting her fur

"I- Oh stars we need to get you cleaned up..." She spoke

"That bad, huh?" Catra rasped

Adora summoned her sword and turned it into a knife "Your clothes are a mess, we're gonna need to cut them-"

Catra flinched as she saw the knife

Adora's brows furrowed before the realization hit her "Sorry" She said apologetically before transforming it again into a scissor

Catra let Adora slowly cut the clothes off and toss them aside

Adora seemed to get more and more horrified as every little injury became properly visible, from the burns to the bruises to the

broken bones

Catra barely spoke to her, knowing what was coming up

Adora slowly lifted her girlfriend into her arms again, being as gentle and careful as she carried her over to the bathroom

"Not water" Catra groaned as Adora placed her in the tub before turning on the warm water

"It's just for abit, we just need to get all the blood and gunk out, it'll feel good, I promise" Adora reassured her as the water slowly filled up to Catra's shoulders

Every few seconds, as Adora picked at her fur and wounds, Catra would hiss and lurch

And every few seconds Adora would reassure her by saying "I'm right here..."

After awhile Catra just let Adora's touch keep her calm, almost slipping into sleep in the blonde's arms. Adora had to remove dirt from her tail at one point, and while she usually always minded someone touching her tail, she let Adora's hands glide over it like it was nothing

Adora had to rub the blood off Catra's neck and face with her own hands, and that seemed to be the point where the inevitable happened

"You're an idiot...Y'know that?" She finally began to tear up "You just had to- you had to give yourself up for me- you couldn't just, save yourself for once-"

Catra really didn't want to have this conversation

She looked up at Adora with half-lidded eyes "When are you gonna get it through your thick, dumb head that you're important to me" She complained "Like it or not, I'm always gonna save you before I even think of saving myself, if I have to live with you doing that, you're gonna have to live with me doing this"

"You shouldn't have to save me!" Adora cried "You shouldn't have to protect me when it gets you hurt! you should've gone with Micah, you should've let them take me, hell, you should've just given him our location instead of letting him torture you!"

"You'd never tell him either" Catra replied

"I can't live without you, okay? I-I'd never forgive myself if something happened to you, even now, I can't see you hurt- You've been hurting all your life, I can't let- I don't want it to happen again- I wanna be able to protect you"

"And your way of doing that is surrendering and giving yourself up? I tried to warn you, I told you not to show up and you still did, how's that fair?" Catra argued "I'm not gonna regret what I did, I'd do it again if I had to, you're gonna have to deal with it"

Adora pulled her close, drifting her through the silky water and into the warmth of her body, there was no arguing with Catra here and she knew it "just please, *please* don't get yourself hurt again" she pleaded

"No promises..." Catra replied

She slowly carried Catra back out, setting her down on the carpet as she dried her with a towel before going back to put on her own clothes

Her fingers quaked as they brushed over Catra's exposed wounds

"If I *ever* see him again, I'm not holding back"

She brought out the first aid kit, putting some alcohol on the cotton and dabbing it onto the cuts. Catra hissed and winced but she did her best not to pull away. Every small noise of discomfort her girlfriend made fueled Adora's ire even more. She had half a mind to go wherever the Rebellion was holding that guy and kill him

"I think you already haven't held back..." She flinched as Adora began applying it to her arm "The entire throne room was on fire, there was lightning all over, you were glowing flying through the air, it was...scary"

"I'm sorry, I didn't mean to go that far, it just sorta...happened" Adora said softly

"Don't apologize...just don't do anything that crazy again" Catra flinched again as Adora started cleaning the cuts on her leg "Seeing you like that...it's not the best experience"

"I won't" Adora replied quietly before bringing out the bandages

Catra looked up at her "And...don't walk into traps for me again either"

"Oh so you getting captured for me is fair but me trying to save you isn't?" Adora huffed

Catra sniffled "I mean it...don't do that" Tears started to build in her eyes again "I was fine with all this, I was fine with getting hurt but, when I heard you were coming, I was actually scared"

Adora paused and looked up at her, Catra rarely ever admitted she was scared

"I was freaking out when you showed up, I kept hoping you wouldn't, and then you surrendered, and I couldn't do anything about it- You-You're the idiot here if you thought that was okay" She ranted

"Catra..." Adora moved to sit next to her "It's okay, it's over..."

"And then you had the audacity to tell me 'it's okay', no it wasn't! I-I didn't know what was gonna happen to you, they could've killed you because of me! You shouldn't have shown up..." She buried her head in the crook of Adora's neck, wincing a little as her bruise flared in pain "Adora...don't *ever* scare me like that again"

Adora sighed, wrapping her arms around her girlfriend "I can't say I'm not gonna do that for you because I will. Catra, you're everything to me, if-if someone's after you...if someone hurts you...I'll always show up to protect you, even if it gets me hurt..."

Catra opened her mouth to say something then closed it again

"I'm sorry for scaring you but...I'll always come for you, no matter what, you can't stop me from doing that" She kissed her forehead before continuing to bandage her up, looping her arms round Catra's slim figure to cover her back

Catra sighed, knowing there was no reasoning with Adora here "Just please *try* not to get yourself hurt?"

"No promises" Adora replied as she wrapped the bandages around Catra's torso

"These are gonna take forever to heal, even with magic" Catra observed as Adora continued to work "...And the dressings are gonna take forever to change"

"I'm up for it" Adora said quickly "I know you don't like anyone else doing it" She paused "And I'll try to heal everything, even if it goes slowly"

"You sure? It always drains you doesn't it? I'm kinda surprised you haven't collapsed yet" Catra flinched again "I don't wanna be the reason you're all drained"

Adora finished bandaging her back and wrapped her arms around her from behind, planting a kiss over the scar on the back of her neck "I'm always up if it means making you feel better, I know we're gonna have to fix and rebuild Brightmoon, but whenever you need me...I'll be here, every step of the way"

She got up and walked around to start bandaging Catra's leg

"When I get up, I have to plan the relief efforts" Catra mused "I head a couple blasts last night, I wanna be able to help fix things"

Adora looked up at her "No way, you aren't walking around in your condition, especially not down the stairs"

"I'm *fine* Adora" She tried "You're not keeping me cooped up in this room"

"Fine, then I'll carry you wherever you want" She huffed "You're *not* walking with a bullet hole in your leg and a stab wound in your arm"

"They're partially healed!" Catra argued "And I don't need you carrying me around like a baby, it's embarrassing!"

"No it's not" Adora said firmly "It's not embarrassing when you're hurt and someone's taking care of you"

"It is to you, I don't need you slaving away for me" She tried

"Try me, I'll do it for as long as it takes for you to get better" Adora finished up with her leg "Done"

Catra rolled her eyes "You're gonna have to do it again in a couple of hours"

Adora smiled "Then I'll do it again" She walked to the closet to get Catra some loose fitting, clean clothes and helped her struggle into them, then she lifted her into her arms and lay her back down on the bed. Catra finally let out a soft purr as she snuggled into the sheets

"You sleep, okay? I'll keep watch in case there are any left in the castle" She brushed her hand over Catra's hair

Even when it was bruised up, Adora still thought Catra had the most beautiful face in the world

Catra yawned and blinked at her "I think you already had them all running"

Adora nodded "Still, I wanna be able to protect you, just in case"

"Hey Adora?" Catra said quietly, about to doze off "I love you..."

A warmth bloomed in Adora's chest as she heard it, it felt nice to finally be around her again after being separated

She covered Catra with the blanket, planting a kiss on her forehead again "I love you too..."

There was alot left to do between cleaning up here, getting justice, and helping her girlfriend fully recover. Adora knew she'd be needed soon, she'd have to multitask, she had to help the

alliance hunt these people down and fix whatever they broke, but she knew without a shadow of a doubt that she'd do her best to be there for Catra. No matter how much carrying her around or pushing her on a wheelchair or changing her bandages or using magic to heal her exhausted Adora, she'd be there, every step of the way

Adora was Catra's hero first, she'd just have to balance with Brightmoon

End Notes

I warned ya'll, blame the HTTYD fandom for the gore

Am I really writing this long a fic a month before boards? Ya'll bet I am. The minute these exams end tho, get ready for some looooooooooong fics

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!